

HOW COMMUNITIES CAN STOP DESTRUCTIVE DEVELOPMENT PROJECTS IN DOMINICA

Complete Community Opposition How-To

This guide is built around Dominica's distinctive lever — building a consensus and a mass petition at home, mobilising the island's Nature Island identity, enlisting allies abroad, and carrying the objection directly to a foreign company's shareholders and reputation in its own country — and it names the tools you'll meet (the community consensus, the petition, the shareholders' meeting, the international allies) in plain words.

INTRODUCTION & FRAMEWORK

When a **foreign mining giant** planned a **copper mine** that would have torn through a **tenth of the Nature Island's rainforest**, and the government **rushed a law through parliament in a single day** to clear the way — making environmental assessment **optional** and handing over prospecting rights to a huge swathe of the island for almost nothing — the odds looked hopeless. But a local **agronomist**, working through a small conservation association, did something methodical: he talked with community leaders and built a **consensus**; he ran a **petition that thousands of Dominicans signed**; he brought in **allies abroad** who knew how to trace the company's owners; and then, decisively, he carried the islanders' objection **straight to the company's own shareholders' meeting on the other side of the world**. Faced with that pressure, the company's chairman **pledged not to go ahead without the informed consent of Dominicans** — and within months the company **pulled out of the island altogether**. The mine was never built. The rainforest still stands. Downstream of the proposed workings lay the land of the island's indigenous community — the last of its kind in the region — and it too was spared.

The Dominican agronomist who turned back a copper-mining giant drew on tools available to any community facing a distant company. The decisive one is the **foreign company's shareholders and reputation at home** — where a distant giant is unexpectedly weak, because it needs a good name and the confidence of its owners far more than it fears a local protest it never has to see. **International allies** can trace a foreign company's owners and reach its home country, carrying an island's objection to the company's own shareholders' meeting; protest, petition, and lawful advocacy are the tools. The island's **Nature Island identity** is a powerful, unifying cause that makes the reputational stakes bite. And a broad community consensus and a mass petition — thousands of signatures — turn opposition into a visible, countable fact the company's owners cannot dismiss. But these tools have real limits, and this guide states them plainly. The lever works best against a **foreign company vulnerable to its reputation and shareholders** at home; a purely domestic or state-driven project offers less of that soft spot. The government of the day was willing to **rush a law through in a day** and soften environmental assessment, so the domestic ground was tilted. And the win rested on building a **genuine, broad consensus** — not a few loud voices — which takes patient work. So aim for what this lever can deliver by finding where a distant giant is weak and pressing there.

The Whole Strategy in One Idea

A foreign giant looks unstoppable, but it has a soft spot — its name and its shareholders at home — and a chain breaks at its weakest link. A Dominican fight turns on the **community consensus** and the **mass petition** at home; on the **Nature Island identity** that unifies; on the **international allies** who reach the

company's home; and, decisively, on the **shareholders' meeting and the company's reputation** in its own country. Every one of those is a link you can grab — and the shareholder-and-reputation pressure abroad is the one that beat the mine. **Find the one closest to your hand and pull.**

Be Honest About Which Fight You're In

Before you spend months on this, work out your real situation:

- **If it's a foreign company vulnerable to its reputation, the shareholder-and-reputation lever is your sharpest** — a distant giant is weak where its owners and good name are, at home.
- **If you can build a genuine, broad consensus, the mass petition makes it countable** — thousands of signatures turn opposition into an undeniable fact.
- **If the island's identity is at stake, the Nature Island cause unifies** — Dominica's forest identity is a powerful rallying ground.
- **If allies abroad can trace the owners, enlist them** — they know how to reach a foreign company's shareholders and home-country press.

Read the whole guide once before you move. Two habits run through it: **build a genuine, broad consensus and a mass petition at home, and find where the distant giant is weak — its shareholders and reputation abroad — and press there.** That's how the Nature Island turned back a mining giant.

HOW THE SYSTEM WORKS

To break the chain you have to see it — who decides, how a project moves, and where a foreign giant is weak.

Who Actually Decides

The government grants the rights and can tilt the domestic ground — it rushed the mining law through in a day and softened environmental assessment. But a **foreign company** answers to its **shareholders and its reputation** in its own country, and to **international allies and press** who can reach them. The **community**, through a **broad consensus and a mass petition**, and the island's **Nature Island identity**, hold real moral force. Know which of these you can reach — the foreign company's shareholders and name are the sharpest, where a distant giant is weak.

How a Project Moves — and Where You Jump In

The domestic grant and law. The government grants rights, perhaps tilting the ground. *Your opening:* build the consensus and petition to deny the project legitimacy.

The community consensus and petition. *Your opening — the foundation:* the slow work of genuine consensus, then a mass petition that makes it countable.

The international allies. *Your opening:* allies abroad who trace the company's owners and reach its home country.

The shareholders and reputation. *Your opening — the decisive stroke:* carry the objection to the company's own shareholders' meeting and its reputation at home, where it is weak.

Follow the Money and the Permissions

Dig up three things. **Who owns the foreign company, and where** — because its shareholders and home-country reputation are the pressure point. **What it needs and what it fears** — a good name, its owners' confidence — the soft spot of a distant giant. **How broad your consensus is** — because a genuine, countable consensus, not a few voices, is what makes the objection credible abroad.

Who's Supposed to Be Watching

Each is an ally or an arena. The **foreign company's shareholders** hold its direction and its conscience. Its **reputation and home-country press** are its vulnerability. **International allies** trace the owners and reach them. The **community consensus and petition** and the **Nature Island identity** are the moral force. And Dominica's **conservation associations, community leaders, and international solidarity networks** are the forces that reach furthest — the coalition that beat the mine.

QUICK REFERENCE: SUCCESS RATES

Size up the odds honestly. These are rough patterns, not promises. What most moves them: whether the company is a foreign one vulnerable to its reputation, whether you can build a genuine broad consensus, and whether allies can reach its shareholders.

What you do	Roughly works	How long	Cost	What "works" means
Just gather documents	5–10%	weeks	low	The base for everything else
Build a genuine, broad consensus	25–50%	weeks–months	low	Real, unified opposition
Mass petition (thousands of signatures)	30–55%	weeks–months	low	Opposition made countable
Mobilise the Nature Island identity	25–50%	weeks–months	low	A unifying national cause
Enlist international allies (trace the owners)	30–55%	months	low	Reach to the company's home
Shareholder + reputation pressure abroad	40–65%	months	low	The decisive stroke (mine beaten)
Confront a foreign company at home + overseas	35–60%	months	low	Project made a liability abroad
Everything together (consensus, petition, allies, shareholders)	45–70%	months	low	Company pulled out; forest saved
Against a purely domestic / state project	15–35%	months–yr	low	Less reputational soft spot

The levers that move the needle most are the **shareholder-and-reputation pressure abroad** and the **mass petition and consensus** at home, with **international allies** to reach the company's owners. Dominica shows the ceiling (a mining giant pulled out, a tenth of the rainforest and the indigenous community's land saved) and the honest floor (it works best against a reputation-vulnerable foreign company, the government tilted the domestic ground, and it took patient consensus). So aim for a company pulled out, a project made a liability abroad, and consent established as the condition.

On cost: the consensus, the petition, the Nature Island cause, and reaching the shareholders cost mainly organised effort and international solidarity, not money. The great strength is finding where a distant giant is weak — its name and its owners at home; the great requirement is a genuine, broad, countable consensus that makes the objection credible abroad.

STEP 1: TARGET IDENTIFICATION

Being against "the mine" is weak. Being specific — this foreign owner, this shareholders' meeting, this countable consensus — is strong. Answer five questions in writing.

- 1. What is it, and who owns it — and where?** Name the project and, crucially, the **foreign company and its owners and home country**, because its shareholders and reputation there are your sharpest lever.
- 2. What does it destroy?** Map it over the **rainforest, the Nature Island's identity, the water, and the communities** — including any indigenous land downstream, as at the copper mine.
- 3. What stage is it at, and where is the company weak?** Is a grant or law in play? When is the **shareholders' meeting**? Where is the company reputationally exposed at home? These are the openings.
- 4. How broad is your consensus — and can you make it countable?** Whether you can build a **genuine, broad consensus** (not a few voices) and a **mass petition** that turns it into an undeniable fact.
- 5. Who are your allies abroad?** **International allies** who can trace the owners and reach the company's shareholders and home-country press. The agronomist's campaign joined all of these.

What this looks like in real life. A foreign mining giant seeks to tear through a tenth of the island's rainforest, the government having tilted the ground. The five questions yield: the foreign company and its owners abroad (your sharpest lever); the rainforest, the Nature Island identity, and the indigenous land; a shareholders' meeting to target; a broad consensus and petition to build; and international allies to reach the company's home. That's the Dominica pattern — build the consensus and petition, mobilise the Nature Island identity, and carry the objection to the company's shareholders and reputation abroad.

STEP 2: DOCUMENTATION

The difference between a community that can fight and one that can't is proof — of the harm, and of a genuine, countable consensus. Build it in three layers.

Layer one: the harm and the identity. Document what the project would **destroy** — the tenth of the rainforest, the Nature Island's identity, the water, the indigenous land downstream — with evidence and testimony, because this is the case you carry to the shareholders and the world.

Layer two: the consensus and the petition. Build and document a **genuine, broad consensus** through patient work with community leaders, then a **mass petition** that turns it into a visible, countable fact — thousands of signatures, as at the copper mine. This is what makes the objection credible abroad.

Layer three: the ownership map. With allies abroad, trace **who owns the foreign company and where**, and identify its **shareholders' meeting and reputational exposure** at home — the decisive pressure point. Walking into the shareholders' meeting, the international press, or the company's home country with the documented harm, the countable consensus, and the ownership map is what makes a distant giant pull out.

WHAT TO GATHER, AND WHERE TO FIND IT

- **The harm** — the rainforest, the Nature Island identity, the water, the indigenous land — with evidence and testimony.
- **The consensus** — genuine and broad, built through patient work.
- **The mass petition** — thousands of signatures, making opposition countable.
- **The ownership map** — who owns the company and where, traced with allies abroad.
- **The shareholders' meeting and reputational exposure** — the decisive pressure point.

STEP 3: BUILDING LOCAL OPPOSITION

Documents give you a case; a genuine consensus, a mass petition, and allies abroad give you the power that beat a mining giant. Build in four moves.

Do the patient work of genuine consensus. The campaign began with the slow work of talking with community leaders until there was a **real consensus** — not a few loud voices. Do that patient work; it is the foundation of everything.

Turn it into a countable petition. Run a **mass petition** that thousands sign, turning the consensus into a visible, undeniable fact — the proof of opposition you carry abroad.

Mobilise the Nature Island identity, and enlist allies abroad. Rally the island's **Nature Island identity** as a unifying cause, and enlist **international allies** who know how to trace the company's owners and reach its home country.

Carry it to the shareholders — the decisive stroke. The task is not to overpower the company at home but to **make the project a liability for it abroad**. Build an opposition so broad and documented that the company's own **shareholders and reputation** become the pressure point — carrying the objection to their own meeting, in their own country, until proceeding without consent becomes untenable.

STEP 4: THE CONSENSUS, THE PETITION & THE SHAREHOLDERS

Dominica's sharpest levers run from a genuine consensus at home to the company's shareholders and reputation abroad.

The Consensus and the Mass Petition

Start at home: build a **genuine, broad consensus** through patient work with community leaders, then a **mass petition** that thousands sign, turning opposition into a countable, undeniable fact. A company can absorb a few loud voices; it cannot easily dismiss a whole island, documented.

The Nature Island Identity and International Allies

Mobilise the island's **Nature Island identity** as a unifying cause that carries far, and enlist **international allies** who can trace the company's owners and reach its shareholders and home-country press — the reach that turns a local objection into a global one.

The Shareholders and Reputation — the Decisive Lever

The decisive stroke: carry the islanders' objection **directly to the foreign company's shareholders' meeting and its reputation in its own country**, where a distant giant is unexpectedly weak. Faced with its own owners being told it is forcing an opposed, reputationally damaging project onto a small island without consent, the company's calculus changes — as at the copper mine, where the chairman pledged not to proceed without Dominicans' informed consent, and the company pulled out within months.

The Honest Limits

Straight talk: this lever is powerful, but it works best against a **foreign company vulnerable to its reputation and shareholders**; a purely domestic or state project offers less soft spot, and the government can tilt the domestic ground. So use the levers — the consensus, the petition, the Nature Island identity, the allies, and above all the shareholder-and-reputation pressure abroad — and count a company pulled out, a project made a liability abroad, and consent established as the condition as wins.

TURNING YOUR EVIDENCE INTO ARGUMENTS

A stack of documents wins nothing until you aim it.

Harm becomes a reputational risk abroad. Not "we oppose the mine" but *"your company is forcing a mine through a tenth of a Nature Island's rainforest, against a whole island's documented opposition — is that the name you want?"*

A petition becomes an undeniable fact. *"Thousands of Dominicans have signed against this — this is not a few voices but an island."*

The Nature Island identity becomes a cause. *"This is the Nature Island — its forest is its identity and its future."*

The shareholders become the deciders. *"Your own owners should know what is being done in their name, without the community's consent."*

Match it to the venue: the harm and the petition to the shareholders and the international press; the Nature Island identity to the public and the allies; the consent condition to the company's chairman and board.

STEP 5: MEDIA STRATEGY

In Dominica, international attention is the decisive lever, because a foreign company's reputation in its own country is where it is weak — and the Nature Island identity carries far. International allies and press make the media front reach the company's home.

Lead with the Nature Island and the opposed giant, not procedure. Not "the mining law was flawed" but "a foreign mining giant forcing a copper mine through a tenth of the Nature Island's rainforest, against a whole island's opposition." Use your strongest material: the harm, the countable petition, the Nature Island identity, and the company's own name.

Work several audiences at once. Dominican press and public build the consensus and the petition; the company's **home-country press and shareholders** are the decisive audience, where its reputation is exposed. Make it easy: clear summaries, the petition numbers, images of the forest.

Two hard rules. Accuracy above all — one exaggeration can discredit the objection carried to shareholders. And carry a genuine, broad, documented consensus — the credibility that a distant giant cannot dismiss.

EMAILS & LETTERS

Make them your own; keep them short, exact and calm; keep a copy of everything.

8A — Building consensus (to community leaders).

Subject: Our forest and [project] — let's find our common voice.

"We, [group], ask the community leaders to meet and build a genuine, shared position on [project], which threatens [a tenth of our rainforest / our identity]. A united island is our strength. [Contact.]"

8B — Launching the mass petition.

Subject: Sign against [project] — for the Nature Island.

"We, [group], are gathering signatures against [project], which would [destroy a tenth of our rainforest]. Please sign, and turn our opposition into a fact no one can ignore. [Contact.]"

8C — To international allies (trace the owners).

Subject: Help us reach [company]'s owners abroad.

"[Company] plans [project] against our island's documented opposition. We ask your help to trace its owners and reach its shareholders and home-country press, as Dominica's anti-mine campaign did. [Contact and evidence summary.]"

8D — To the foreign company's shareholders / board.

Subject: [Project] on [island] — forced without the community's consent.

"We are the community of [island]. [Company] is pursuing [project] against the documented opposition of thousands of us, threatening [a tenth of our rainforest and our indigenous community's land]. We ask you: should this proceed in your name, without our informed consent? [Contact and evidence summary.]"

8E — Mobilising the Nature Island identity.

Subject: Our identity, our forest — let's defend the Nature Island.

"[Project] threatens the forest that is the Nature Island's identity and future. Let's unite the island to defend it, at home and abroad. [Contact.]"

8F — To the company (the consent condition).

Subject: No consent — reputational and legal risk — [project].

"We are the community affected by [project]. It proceeds against our documented opposition and without our informed consent, and we are carrying that to your shareholders and the press. We ask you to pledge not to proceed without the community's informed consent. [Contact and evidence summary.]"

8G — Letter to the (international) press.

Subject: A mining giant forces a mine through the Nature Island's rainforest.

"[Company] plans a mine through a tenth of Dominica's rainforest, against a whole island's opposition. We can provide the harm, the petition, and the Nature Island's story. [Contact.]"

8H — Uniting the island.

Subject: Our island, our forest — let's turn back the giant.

"[Project] threatens a tenth of our rainforest. An agronomist and a small association once beat a mining giant by building consensus, a petition thousands signed, and by carrying our objection to the company's own shareholders abroad. Let's do it again. [Contact.]"

IF YOU HAVE LITTLE TIME OR FEW RESOURCES: THE RAPID-FIRE VERSION

If you must move fast and lean — and this lever is low-cost — do these six things, in order:

1. **Build a genuine, broad consensus with community leaders (8A).**
2. **Run a mass petition that thousands sign (8B).**
3. **Mobilise the Nature Island identity (8E).**
4. **Enlist international allies to trace the company's owners (8C).**
5. **Carry the objection to the company's shareholders and reputation abroad (8D/8G).**
6. **Press for the consent condition until the company pulls out (8F).**

Even lean, those six build the consensus and press the shareholders abroad — the Dominica template.

WHEN THE SYSTEM IS TILTED

Dominica's lever is powerful, but the domestic ground can be tilted, and you must plan for it.

When the government tilts the domestic ground. It rushed the mining law through in a day and softened environmental assessment. Don't fight only on that tilted ground — take the fight to where the foreign company is weak, its shareholders and reputation abroad.

When the company is a distant giant. That is its vulnerability, not its strength: it needs a good name and its owners' confidence at home, and cannot easily ignore an opposed, documented project raised at its own shareholders' meeting.

When you need a credible objection. Build a genuine, broad, countable consensus — a mass petition, not a few voices — because that credibility is what a distant giant cannot dismiss.

When the project is domestic or state-driven. The reputational soft spot is smaller. Lean harder on the consensus, the petition, the Nature Island identity, and any international allies and standards you can reach.

WHEN IT'S ACTUAL CORRUPTION — AND WHO'S CAPTURED

Dominica's rushing of a mining law through parliament in a single day, and the softening of environmental assessment, show how the domestic ground can be captured, so this matters.

How to spot it. Laws rushed through to clear the way; environmental assessment softened from mandatory to optional; prospecting rights handed over for almost nothing; benefits to the connected while the forest and communities bear the harm.

Who's supposed to guard against it. Dominica's audit and oversight bodies examine public money and conduct. The **community consensus and petition** deny a captured project legitimacy. **International allies and the company's shareholders** can be told what is being done in their name. And Dominica's **conservation associations and press** can expose a bad deal.

How to fight it safely. Document precisely and factually — how the law was rushed, how assessment was softened, who benefits — and keep clear the line between what you can prove and what you suspect. Carry the exposure to the company's shareholders and the international press, where a distant giant is exposed, rather than relying only on the tilted domestic ground. Pair it with the consensus and the petition.

INTEGRATION & TIMELINE

Don't run these steps one after another — run them together. The documented harm builds your case; the consensus and the petition make it countable; the Nature Island identity unifies; the international allies reach the company's home; and the shareholders and reputation abroad are the decisive stroke. Together they multiply. One at a time, they stall.

Early on (weeks 1–8): document the harm; build a genuine, broad consensus; launch the mass petition; mobilise the Nature Island identity; enlist international allies to trace the owners.

In the thick of it (months): carry the objection to the company's shareholders' meeting and home-country press; press the consent condition; make the project a liability abroad.

The long haul (months+): hold the company to its pledge; keep the consensus and the allies ready; hold the line for a company pulled out, a project made a liability abroad, and consent established as the condition.

FINAL ASSESSMENT

Stopping a destructive project in Dominica can be done — a local agronomist and a small conservation association turned back one of the largest mining companies on earth, and a tenth of the Nature Island's rainforest and the indigenous community's land still stand. Hold both truths. Dominica's distinctive power is real: a community can build a consensus and a mass petition at home, mobilise the island's Nature Island identity, enlist allies abroad, and take its objection directly to a foreign company's shareholders and reputation in its own country — until proceeding without consent becomes untenable. And the constraints are real: the lever works best against a reputation-vulnerable foreign company, the government can tilt the domestic ground, and the win rests on patient, genuine consensus.

Here's the discipline that wins. Do the patient work of building a genuine, broad consensus with community leaders — not a few loud voices — then run a mass petition that thousands sign, turning opposition into a countable, undeniable fact. Mobilise the Nature Island identity as a unifying cause, and enlist international allies who can trace the foreign company's owners and reach its home country. Then, decisively, carry the islanders' objection directly to the company's own shareholders' meeting and its reputation in its own country, where a distant giant is unexpectedly weak — making the project a liability abroad until the company pledges not to proceed without the community's informed consent. Count a company pulled out, a project made a liability abroad, and consent established as the condition as wins. That is how the Nature

Island's defenders prevailed — not by force, but by finding where a distant giant was vulnerable and pressing there. So can you.